In Moravia, the arrival of two Greek preachers, Cyril (also known as Constantine) and Methodius, challenged the plans of Frankish missionaries and politicians. Under some pressure, the disciples of these two brothers were expelled and Moravia, together with Carantania to the south (a principality of early Slovenians that covered roughly the same territory as the Austrian province of Carinthia today), came under Bavarian political influence. The Bavarians themselves had already been subdued by the Franks, converted about the same time as Slovenians. Christianisation was interrupted for a while by the arrival of the Avars (one of the ancestors of the Magyars) but Frankish help to the Slavs as they defended themselves against the new arrivals tightened the Bavarian/Frankish grip. After a brief but very important Irish mission (St Ferghal was bishop of Salzburg and he is still regarded as the Apostle of the Carantanians, i.e. the early Slovenians), Carantanians as well as other Slavs in Central Europe came under Germanic ecclesiastical control.

Further to the north, the early Bohemian rulers were looking westward too. Magdeburg became the centre for the Christianisation of western Slavs. In 964, Poles acquired Christianity from Bohemians through royal marriage. Later on, Poles and Czechs would be among the few Slavic nations able to establish their own church provinces directly reporting to Rome, which would enable them to maintain, at least for some time, a fair degree of political independence.

The Hungarians, one of the non-Slavic nations of Eastern Europe, initially came under Greek influence but German clergy prevailed after AD 980. Christianity was thus firmly established in the whole of Eastern Europe by the early years of the eleventh century. The exception was Lithuania, which only ceased to be formally pagan in 1385 when, again through marriage, its rulers accepted the Roman Catholic faith from Poles.

Without going into too much detail and for the purpose of our further discussion, it is important to note that Europe, in these early centuries in the form of the Christendom of Charlemagne, already included a great part of what today is popularly called Eastern Europe. By the fourteenth century, when ‘Europe’ got an even better defined shape and the Holy Roman Empire of the German Nation (a union of small principalities that were mostly but not exclusively German-speaking and that much later gave birth to what is today known as Germany) was firmly established, the political